



“A student is working on *their* own project”: a systematic review of epicene singular *they* by learners of English

Hanzhong Sun¹ · Xiao Peter LUO² · Hye K. Pae¹

Received: 22 December 2024 / Accepted: 3 January 2026
© The Author(s) 2026

Abstract

Gender-neutral language serves as a powerful tool for promoting gender equality and inclusivity in today’s gender-diverse world. Among such linguistic devices, singular *they*, proposed as an alternative to generic *he* and the paired form *he or she*, has recently garnered notable attention as an epicene pronoun, used to refer to a generic individual whose gender is unknown or unspecified. In this systematic review, we synthesized existing empirical research on singular *they* as an epicene pronoun among learners of English as a second or foreign language. We also surveyed the methodological characteristics of these studies and summarized the factors influencing learners’ engagement with singular *they*. An analysis of 18 studies yielded three key findings. First, researchers employed diverse data sources to investigate how learners from various first language backgrounds *used*, *perceived*, and *processed* singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts. However, most studies focused on college-aged learners’ *use* of singular *they* by utilizing elicitation instruments. Second, while earlier studies reported a predominant use of generic *he*, recent research revealed an upward trend in using singular *they*, signaling a gradual shift in epicene pronoun usage among learners. Learners generally did not experience difficulty processing singular *they*, but mixed attitudes – both positive and negative – along with discrepancies between perception and practice were observed regarding singular *they*. Third, a range of learner, linguistic, and contextual factors were shown to influence learners’ pronominal preference for singular *they* over generic *he* and *he or she*, underscoring the complexity of this linguistic phenomenon. Pedagogical implications and recommendations for future research are also discussed.

Keywords Epicene pronouns · Singular *they* · Learners of English as a second or foreign language · Methodological characteristics · Influencing factors · Gender equality and inclusivity

Extended author information available on the last page of the article

Published online: 04 February 2026

Introduction

As both spoken and written language affects human cognition (Pae 2020), such as gender perception (Samuel et al. 2019), efforts to use gender-inclusive language have been made to avoid marginalizing certain social groups (Nunez-Roman et al. 2023; Wyrick 2021). In English, for example, *police officer* and *mail carrier* are preferred over the gendered forms *policeman* and *mailman* to include feminine representation. In a similar vein, the adoption of epicene pronouns—third-person singular pronouns used to refer to a generic gender-unspecified individual—has also evolved over the past decades (Barron 2020). Prescriptive English grammar has long subscribed to the masculine *he*¹ as the default epicene pronoun (Taylor 2021), which does not acknowledge female presence in linguistic pragmatics (Miller and James 2009). Along with the recent endorsements of the seventh edition of the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* (henceforth APA; American Psychological Association 2019) and the ninth edition of the *MLA Handbook* (Modern Language Association 2021), however, the use of the epicene singular *they* has dramatically increased in place of the masculine generic *he* (Bradley 2020; Noll et al. 2018; Stormbom 2019).

While the first occurrence of singular *they* was traced back to the fourteenth century (Peterson 2014), its popularization has been a relatively recent phenomenon, propelled by the nonsexist or feminist language reform since the 1970s (Mucchi-Faina 2005). Singular *they* does not presume or privilege any particular gender in contexts where gender is unspecified; instead, it provides a more comprehensive representation of gender identities, inclusive of not only female but also non-binary gender, such as lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer, intersex, asexual, and beyond (LGBTQIA+). It thus serves as a gender-neutral strategy that linguistically contributes to gender equality and inclusivity in this increasingly gender-diverse world (Stormbom 2024). For this reason, singular *they* has garnered wide acceptance among English-as-a-first-language (L1 English) communities in recent decades. For example, the use of singular *they* has been found to surpass that of generic *he* in British and American newspapers (Baranowski 2002) and in Australian formal speech (Paulwels 2001).

In contrast, English language teaching, particularly in the context of English as a foreign language (EFL), has traditionally been dominated by prescriptive grammar, which is still likely to remain influential (Hinkel 2018). As such, this context may not respond to social movements and their impact on language use in a timely fashion. Consequently, language educators and practitioners may resist incorporating gender perspectives into their teaching (Tarrayo 2023), and discussions about gender issues may even cause psychological and emotional discomfort (Romiti and Smith 2022).

¹ Pronouns take different grammatical forms depending on their function within a sentence, including subject, object, attributive possessive, nominal possessive, and reflective pronouns. For the sake of simplicity, this article uses the subject pronoun form as an umbrella term to encompass all variations. For instance, the generic *he* includes *he*, *him*, *his*, and *himself*.

In the case of epicene pronoun usage, classroom-based instruction may proceed with generic *he* and the paired form *he or she*.²

However, against the backdrop of the global dominance of English (Selvi et al. 2024), international communication in English, whether in-person or virtual, has become increasingly prevalent. In today's globalized world, marked by the ever-increasing flow of people, ideas, and images, a diversity of gender identities has been brought to prominence (Elabor-Idemudia 2011). Therefore, the adoption of singular *they* as the default epicene pronoun is highly beneficial and increasingly necessary in global English contexts, as it supports more inclusive, respectful, and effective intercultural communication (Velázquez-Lora 2022). This usage empowers learners³ to communicate without making gender assumptions in contexts where no specific gender is involved, thus creating a more equitable and accepting environment for all gender identities. Failure to employ such inclusive language as singular *they*, on the other hand, may undermine linguistic efforts to build an inclusive and welcoming space, leading to the alienation of individuals who do not identify themselves within the gender-binary framework.

Given such knowledge, it is crucial to explore the extent to which learners have embraced singular *they*. Understanding how well learners adopt this usage not only provides insights into their evolving language practices and navigation of discussions about gender and language, but also reveals potential gaps in awareness of inclusive language exemplified by singular *they*. As the body of research on this topic has expanded in recent years (e.g., Abudalbuh 2012; LaScotte 2021; Lee 2007; Stormbom 2018; Tarrayo 2024), we present a systematic review synthesizing existing empirical studies addressing singular *they* as an epicene pronoun among learners.

In the remainder of this article, we will first provide a brief overview of the three dominant epicene pronouns and their interrelationships. Then, we will turn to the motivation of the current review before describing the methodology employed to identify and analyze the studies included in this review. Following this, we will present a synthesized analysis of the findings of the target studies. Finally, we will conclude with implications for pedagogical practice and avenues to advance research into singular *they*.

Literature review

English epicene pronoun

The English language lacks a third-person singular pronoun that is entirely gender-neutral. To address this lexical gap, three main epicene pronouns have been widely adopted: generic *he*, *he or she*, and singular *they*. The first two options, however,

² For the sake of brevity, we use *he or she* to refer collectively to its various forms, including *he or she*, *she or he*, *he/she*, *she/he*, *s/he*, *he(she)*, *she(he)*, and *(s)/he*.

³ Since the paper focuses on the English epicene pronoun *they*, we use *learners* instead of *learners of English* for brevity, referring to those learning English as an additional (including second or foreign) language, unless a particular emphasis is needed.

have generated significant criticism. Generic *he* has been problematized with gender discrimination and male dominance (Bailey et al. 2019), exerting harmful effects on females. For example, Stout and Dasgupta (2011) found that women experienced decreased motivation and a reduced sense of belonging during a mock job interview when exposed to this gender-exclusive pronoun.

The paired form *he or she* was introduced as the second gender-indeterminate option to counter male dominance in language use. Variants of this form include *she or he*, *he/she*, *she/he*, *he(she)*, *she(he)*, and *s/he*. While appearing inclusive due to the reference to both traditional genders (male and female), these pronominal forms are imperfect upon scrutiny. The primary shortcoming surrounds their presumption that “gender is binary” (Paterson 2020, p. 259), thereby excluding individuals who identify as gender non-binary or non-conforming, such as members of LGBTQIA communities. A second criticism, applied to *he or she*, *he/she*, and *he(she)*, concerns “the practice of ordering masculine terms before feminine terms” or “man firstness” (Willis and Jozkowski 2018, p. 137), which subtly reinforces gender inequality, as language users are compelled to prioritize one gender over the other in phrasing. Lastly, these paired forms have also been criticized for being cumbersome and wordy due to the repeated mentions of both genders (Baron 2020).

To address the aforementioned shortcomings associated with the paired form *he or she* and its variants, researchers have explored extensively alternative pronouns. These include newly coined pronouns such as *ze*, *xe*, and *hir*, as well as the existing one *they* (see Baron 2020; for a chronological list of epicene pronouns). While many of the proposed replacements have failed to gain widespread acceptance, singular *they* has emerged as “a cognitively efficient substitute” (Foertsch and Gernsbacher 1997, p. 106) and has become widely accepted in L1 English communities (Bradley et al. 2019; LaScotte 2016; Paterson 2014; Pauwels and Winter 2006), despite opposition from prescriptive grammarians and linguists who adhere to rigid syntactic rules (Bradley 2020).

The shift from *he* to *they* as the preferred epicene pronoun was further confirmed in two psycholinguistic experiments by Noll et al. (2018), involving L1 English speakers. Their first priming experiment revealed that the prime “*he*” equally facilitated the reading of masculine- and feminine-gendered words (e.g., *uncle* vs. *mother*), but the prime “*they*” sped up only the reading of the feminine words. These results indicated that only *he* functioned as the epicene pronoun. In a second replication study conducted 15 years later with another group of L1 English speakers, results showed that *he* sped the processing of masculine words but significantly slowed that of their feminine counterparts, whereas *they* produced a comparable facilitation for both gendered words. These findings provide a strong indication of *they* rather than *he* serving as the gender-neutral pronoun.

In summary, the three widely discussed epicene pronouns – generic *he*, *he or she*, and singular *they* – have been highlighted above. Conceptually, however, these pronouns are not equally positioned on an inclusivity spectrum, with singular *they* being perceived as the most inclusive and generic *he* as the least. To further illustrate their distinctions, we provide three hypothetical examples. In Example (a), using generic *he* may imply that the late submission penalty applies only to male students, which reinforces certain gender stereotypes. In Example (b), the paired form *his or her*

excludes gender-nonbinary students, rendering them unwelcome or overlooked. In contrast, Example (c) demonstrates the use of singular *they*, which acknowledges and respects the gender diversity within the student body.

- (a) *The student* who does not submit the assignment on time will have *his* grades deducted.
- (b) To create a relaxing atmosphere, *the student* can bring *his or her* snacks to the class.
- (c) If *someone* needs help with the coursework, *they* should feel free to contact the instructor.

Different types of learner research on singular *they*

Stormbom (2024) reviewed research methods utilized in the current body of literature on singular *they*, identifying three primary approaches: corpus linguistics methods, experimental methods (e.g., elicitation tests, self-paced reading tasks, and eye-tracking measures), and survey methods. Notably, Hyland (2016) placed elicitation tests, surveys, and interviews together under elicitation methods; Avery and Marsden (2019) also grouped self-paced reading tasks as a specific elicitation technique. Given distinct ways to classify these instruments and each of them contributing different perspectives to the understanding of singular *they*, we will examine each individually and address them as *data sources* in our review. In the remainder of this section, we contextualize each data source within studies delving into English epicene pronouns.

Corpora allow researchers to examine the use of singular *they* in authentic and less restrictive contexts. Researchers typically draw on such corpus tools as AntConc and Wordsmith to extract from a given corpus all sentence instances containing *he*, *he or she*, *they*, and other related forms (e.g., *him*, *he/she*, and *their*). They then conduct an intensive manual check to ensure that each pronoun refers to an indefinite pronoun (e.g., *someone*) or a singular gender-indeterminate noun phrase (e.g., *a student*) in context. Pronouns that meet this criterion are subsequently classified as epicene pronouns. With the data being cleaned up, researchers compute the frequency percentage for each epicene pronoun type and then compare these percentages across pronoun types. Caution, however, needs to be exercised that corpus data are usually time-sensitive; data collected in earlier periods may not reflect current usage and, therefore, do not reveal the most recent or ongoing linguistic trends that reflect sociocultural changes. As a representative corpus study, Stojanovska-Ilievska (2024) analyzed essays written by L1 Macedonian learners and examined how the use of epicene pronouns varied by antecedent type, academic year, and learners' gender.

Meanwhile, *elicitation tests* yield focused data on the use of singular *they* within relatively controlled settings. Adopting either comprehension or production formats, elicitation tests are designed to provoke a specific epicene pronoun from learners. Learners respond to each test item by selecting one pronoun from several options or by producing a context-appropriate pronoun that refers anaphorically to a singular gender-unspecified antecedent (e.g., *a student*) in the sentence. For example, Zhang

and Yang (2024) used different multiple-choice tests to explore Chinese EFL teachers' usage of epicene pronouns.

Self-paced reading tasks tap into the real-time processing of singular *they*, offering researchers valuable insights into the difficulty learners may encounter when integrating this pronoun with its corresponding antecedents in sentences. In such tasks, learners are instructed to read sentences, displayed one chunk at a time on the computer screen, as quickly and accurately as possible at their own pace. To proceed to the next chunk, they need to press a button on the button box or the space bar on the keyboard. The reading times for each chunk are recorded, reflecting the ease or difficulty or differential attention allocation in processing. For example, Speyer and Schleef (2019) investigated L1 German learners' online processing of three epicene pronouns (*he*, *he or she*, and *they*).

Surveys reveal learners' attitudes, beliefs, or experiences in relation to the use of singular *they*, or more broadly, inclusive language. For example, Ma et al. (2022) developed a five-point Likert scale to evaluate L1 Chinese learners' levels of agreement on the use of generic *he*, *he or she*, and singular *they* in different contexts.

Interviews, which offer greater interactivity and flexibility compared to surveys (Hyland 2016), are typically employed alongside other instruments, such as elicitation tests, to gain deeper insights into the use or non-use of singular *they*. These insights add another layer of understanding that other sources, such as corpora, cannot provide. For example, Reilly-Thornton (2021) conducted a semi-structured interview to explore reasons or motivations behind participants' use or non-use of singular *they*.

Collectively, examining the strand of research on singular *they* that employs different types of data sources enables researchers and practitioners to gain a comprehensive understanding of its *use*, *processing*, and *perception*.

Existing reviews of singular *they*

Several review studies have been conducted to synthesize the current body of scholarship on singular *they*, which have also inspired the development of our review. For example, Noviana and Indah (2023) reviewed sociolinguistic theories related to singular *they* and important factors that influenced individuals' responses to this usage, including their understanding of the English language and its concept of gender, as well as social attitudes towards non-binary individuals. This review enhanced our understanding of the topic by clarifying a range of variables that contributed to the reconstruction of singular *they*.

Batista da Costa et al. (2024) presented a systematic review exploring how singular *they* had been interpreted, used, and accepted over the past five decades. The review found that the pronoun *they* had become increasingly gender-neutral in meaning, more frequent in use, and more widely accepted over time. The progression shows that *they* has become a fluid, flexible, and adaptable pronoun inclusive of all members of society. The strength of this review lies in its identification of various inflection points that illustrate the evolution of singular *they*.

Stormbom (2024) conducted a traditional narrative review that critically analyzed the literature on singular *they*. Specifically, she identified factors influencing the use

of epicene pronouns (e.g., antecedent type, level of formality in writing, and age group) and summarized the research methods employed in this line of research (e.g., corpus linguistic, experimental, and survey-based approaches). This review provided valuable insights into both substantive and methodological aspects of existing studies, aiding researchers in navigating the current research landscape of this topic.

In sum, existing review studies on singular *they* have primarily centered on socio-linguistic frameworks, historical interpretations, and methodological considerations, addressing the broad literature across L1 and second language (L2) contexts as a whole.

The present review

While previous review articles offer valuable contributions, discussions focusing exclusively on *learner research* remain limited. As such, there has been a lack of systematic understanding regarding how learners embrace singular *they* as a gender-neutral pronoun. This gap motivates and inspires the conception of the present review. Considering the potential of singular *they* to support gender diversity, equality, and inclusivity, along with a growing number of studies conducted on the topic, a synthesis of the overall findings regarding the adoption of singular *they* is warranted.

Beyond the conceptual insights, it is also necessary to provide researchers and practitioners with a holistic view of the methodological characteristics of the identified studies, including learners' L1 backgrounds, educational levels, and data sources. This information affords a contextual understanding of how learners engage with singular *they*. More importantly, delving into the methodological characteristics of these studies also positions us to better identify evidence-based research trends and deficiencies, enabling researchers to advance this line of inquiry effectively.

In addition, as individual studies have examined different factors such as learner-related (e.g., Abudalbh 2012; Lee 2007), linguistic (e.g., Stormbom 2018; Zhang and Yang 2021), and contextual factors (e.g., Stormbom 2019; Zhang and Yang 2024) that may influence learners' performance of singular *they*, a systematic endeavor to synthesize these influencing factors also becomes necessary. Such synthesis provides a refined and nuanced understanding of why learners use or refrain from using singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts, which potentially informs targeted pedagogical practices.

Although Stormbom (2024) offered a meaningful summary of the data collection methods and influencing factors associated with singular *they*, her review focused on purposefully selected studies and integrated research on both L1 speaker and L2 learner populations as a whole. This hinders a comprehensive understanding of learner-specific research on singular *they*.

We adopted the systematic review approach explicated by Ortega (2015; see the Method section below) to synthesize existing empirical research involving learners' practice of singular *they*. Specifically, we examined not only learners' overall performance of singular *they*, but also learner demographics (L1 backgrounds and educational levels), data sources, and factors influencing learners' performances of singular *they*. Accordingly, the present review is structured around three research questions (RQs). It is important to note that the three RQs are descriptive, com-

parative, and explanatory, according to the classification and hierarchy framework of research questions proposed by Gong et al. (2024). Therefore, by addressing both the *what* and the *why*, this review aims for a broad and in-depth exploration of this topic to inform pedagogical practices and guide future research.

RQ1 What are the methodological characteristics of learner research on singular *they* with respect to learners' L1, learners' educational level, and data source?

RQ2 To what extent do learners perform on singular *they* in genderunspecified contexts?"

RQ3 What factors influence learners' performances of singular *they* in gender-unspecified contexts?

Method

In this review, we systematically analyzed studies of interest following the methodology outlined by Ortega (2015). This process involved six key steps: (1) problem specification, (2) literature search and study eligibility criteria, (3) coding book development, (4) coding of studies, (5) data analysis and display, and (6) interpretation and dissemination of research findings.

Literature search

To identify studies relevant to this review, we conducted a comprehensive literature search using two primary sources: (a) EBSCOhost across all existing databases, such as Academic Search Complete, Education Full Text (H.W. Wilson), Education Research Complete, ERIC, Gender Studies Database, Humanities and Social Sciences Index Retrospective: 1907–1984 (H.W. Wilson), Humanities International Complete, Psychology and Behavioral Sciences Collection, Sociological Collection, and Women's Studies International; and (b) Web of Science. These databases contain a majority of representative scholarly journals devoted to gender-, language-, and education-related issues.

The literature search was formally implemented on September 2nd, 2024, following the guidelines of Galvan and Galvan (2017), with no restrictions placed on the publication year. Two sets of search strings were developed based on studies in the field and through an iterative search process, including the content term *singular they*, the population term *second language learners*, and other possible synonymous expressions, as detailed in Table 1. Both sets of search strings were required to appear in the publication abstract simultaneously.

We used Boolean operators "OR" and "AND" to structure the search query as follows: ("singular they" OR "generic pronoun*" OR "epicene pronoun*" OR "epicene they" OR "gender-neutral*" OR "gender fair*" OR "gender-inclusi*" OR "gender-just" OR "genderless" OR "gender equal*" OR "nonsexist") AND ("non-native" OR "nonnative" OR "second language" OR "second language learn*" OR "foreign

Table 1 Search terms used in the literature search

Topic	Search terms
Singular <i>they</i>	singular <i>they</i> , generic pronoun(s), epicene pronoun(s), epicene <i>they</i> , gender-neutral/neutrality, gender fair/fairness, gender-inclusive/inclusion, gender-just, genderless, gender equal/equality, nonsexist
Second language learners	non-native/nonnative, second language, second language learner(s)/learning, foreign language, foreign language learner(s)/learning, addition language, additional language learner(s)/learning, English language, English language learner(s)/learning, ESL, EFL, EAL

language” OR “foreign language learn*” OR “additional language” OR “additional language learn*” OR “English language” OR “English language learn*” OR “ESL” OR “EFL” OR “EAL”).

To enhance the search results, we employed a snowball search method to ensure that we captured a comprehensive array of studies. Specifically, after generating a list of target studies based on the above keyword search and a refinement process according to the inclusion criteria described below, we conducted a backward search by reviewing the reference list of each target study and a forward search by examining the citation history of each target study on the Google Scholar platform. We also browsed the reference lists of three relevant review articles (Batista da Costa et al. 2024; Noviana and Indah 2023; Stormbom 2024). This snowball search was repeated until no new accessible publication emerged.

Our initial search yielded 2,343 publications. After removing the duplicates, 1,429 articles remained in the literature pool for further screening, with the publication year ranging between 1975 and 2024. The earliest publication in the pool dates back to 1975, dovetailing with the period when the second wave of feminism was popularized in the United States (Thompson 2002). During this time, the linguistic enlightenment against generic *he* began to integrate female presence into the language (Milles 2011).

Inclusion criteria

To locate studies for inclusion, we reviewed the title and abstract of each publication based on the inclusion criteria established as follows, and if necessary, we retrieved the full text to determine eligibility. The studies should.

- address the use and/or perception of epicene singular *they*;
- include learners of English as the participants, regardless of their learning contexts and first language backgrounds;
- be empirical, applying quantitative methods, qualitative methods, or mixed methods;
- be journal articles, books, book chapters, conference proceedings, or unpublished theses/dissertations;
- be published in English;
- be available in full text.

Figure 1 illustrates the literature identification, screening, and inclusion processes. Following the screening process above, we identified 15 studies for inclusion. Three additional studies meeting the inclusion criteria were obtained through the snowball search. A total of 18 studies were finally qualified for inclusion in this review, comprising 16 journal articles and two doctoral dissertations.

Coding and analysis procedure

Based on the research questions, we developed a coding framework that encompassed six categories of details, including bibliographic information (author/authors and publication year), learners' L1 background, learners' educational level, data source, major findings (e.g., the predominant epicene pronoun and attitudes), and factors influencing learners' performances of singular *they*. Table 2 provides a summary of the coding details.

A systematic approach was adopted to descriptively analyze the content of the selected articles. The first author of this review article coded each study independently, and the second author then reviewed the coding, with any discrepancies resolved through discussion. The first author read each article in its entirety to gain

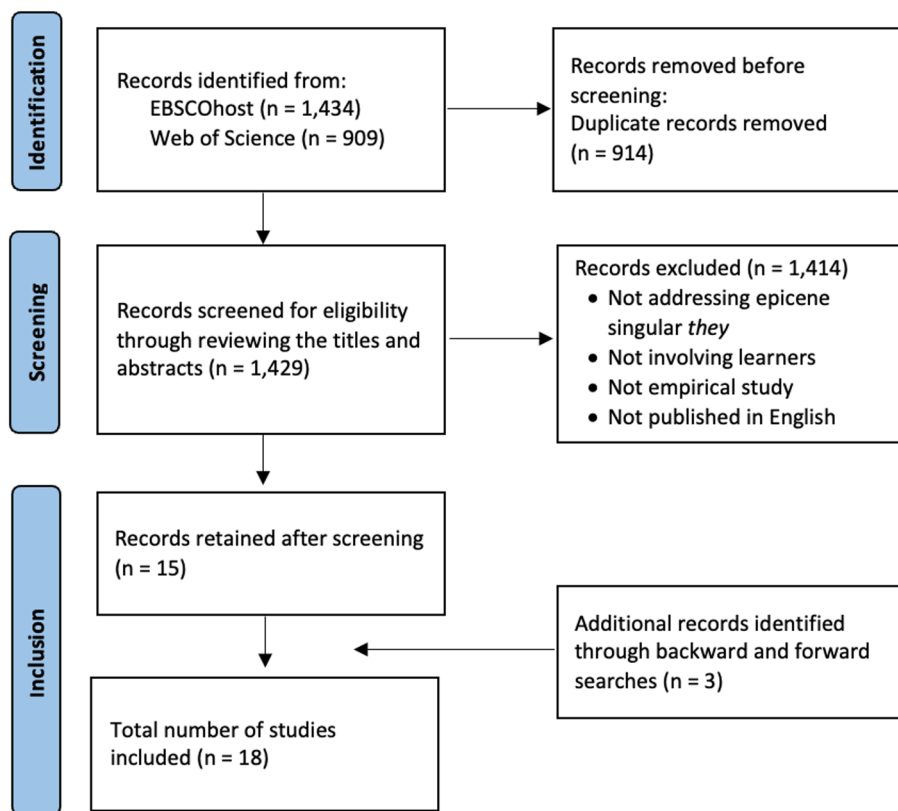


Fig. 1 The PRISMA flow chart for literature search and selection

Table 2 Coding details of each study ($n = 18$)

Study	L1 background	Education- al level	Data source ^d	Influencing factor ^e	Sin- gular they ^f
Lee (2007)	Chinese	Secondary, tertiary	Elicitation test, interview	Learner gender, an- tecedent type, gender stereotyping	No
Sudo (2007)	Russian	Tertiary	Elicitation test, interview	n/a	No
Abudalbuh (2012) ^a	Arabic	Tertiary	Elicitation test	L1, gender stereotyping	No
Lee (2015)	Chinese	Other ^c	Elicitation test, interview	Antecedent type	No
Stormbom (2018) ^a	Thirteen L1s	Tertiary	Corpus (before 2009)	L1, antecedent type, gender stereotyping	No
Speyer & Schleef (2019)	German	Tertiary	Self-paced reading, elicit- ation test, survey	English proficiency, exposure to singular <i>they</i>	Yes
Stormbom (2019)	Swedish	Tertiary	Corpus (1972–2016)	Time, anteced- ent type, gender stereotyping	Yes
Hekanaho (2020) ^a	Finnish, Swedish	Other ^c	Elicitation test, survey	n/a	Yes
Zhang, Hong & Hwang (2020)	Chinese	Tertiary	Elicitation test	Antecedent type, gen- der stereotyping	No
Ebrahimi & Hos- seini (2021)	Polish, Iranian	Tertiary	Elicitation test, survey	Exposure to singular <i>they</i>	Yes
LaScotte (2021)	Seven L1s	Tertiary	Elicitation test	n/a	Yes
Reilly-Thornton (2021)	Chinese	Tertiary	Elicitation test, interview	Antecedent type, exposure to singular <i>they</i>	Yes
Zhang & Yang (2021)	Chinese	Tertiary	Corpus (2003–2007)	Antecedent type	No
Ma, Wu & Xu (2022) ^{a, b}	Chinese	Tertiary	Survey, self- paced reading	English proficiency	Mixed ^g
Ma, Wu & Xu (2022) ^{a, b}	Chinese	Tertiary	Survey, self- paced reading	English proficiency	Mixed ^g
Stormbom (2022)	Eight L1s	Tertiary	Elicitation test	Antecedent type, gen- der stereotyping, L1	Yes
Stojanovska-Ilievs- ka (2024)	Macedonian	Tertiary	Corpus (2015–2017)	Antecedent type	Yes

Table 2 (continued)

Study	L1 background	Education- al level	Data source ^d	Influencing factor ^e	Sin- gular they ^f
Tarrayo (2024)	Filipino	Tertiary	Survey, elicitation test, interview	School culture	Yes
Zhang & Yang (2024)	Chinese	Other ^e	Elicitation test	Antecedent type, gen- der stereotyping	No

Note. The studies are listed based on the publication year

^a marks the inclusion of L1 English speakers for comparative purposes;

^b Ma et al. (2022) conducted two experiments using the same group of learners, and therefore, we considered this an independent study; ^c indicates that the study did not provide specific details about the participants' educational levels, but the participants could be considered as learners of English. For example, Lee (2015) recruited primary and secondary EFL teachers in China; likewise, Zhang & Yang (2024) included Chinese EFL teachers at a tertiary level

^d in studies involving multiple sources, the first source is typically the primary source, except for Ma et al. (2022) and Tarrayo (2024); for the four corpus studies, we also added the time of text collection to help better understand the data

^e only include the factors confirmed to impact learners' performances of singular *they* in each study; note that Hekanaho (2020) investigated many factors, such as gender, age, education, and attitudes towards (non)sexist language use, some of which are found to influence the epicene pronoun use; however, the researcher treated L1 English speakers and learners as a group, so we decided not to consider these influencing factors

^f indicates the general support for singular *they* as an epicene pronoun

^g the study reported contradictory findings in two experiments

an overall understanding of the study. He then perused each study a second time to identify all required information. Specifically, learners' L1 and educational level, along with data source, were extracted from the methods section of each study; major findings were identified in the results and conclusion sections; influencing factors were identified through careful readings of research questions, research design, and the results and discussion sections. All information was collected and organized into a self-designed data matrix spreadsheet.

To answer the RQs, among the coding categories, learners' L1 background, educational level, and data source were located and retrieved to shed light on RQ1. Major findings, along with the learners' L1, educational level, and data sources, helped illuminate RQ2. Influencing factors and major findings were extracted to address RQ3.

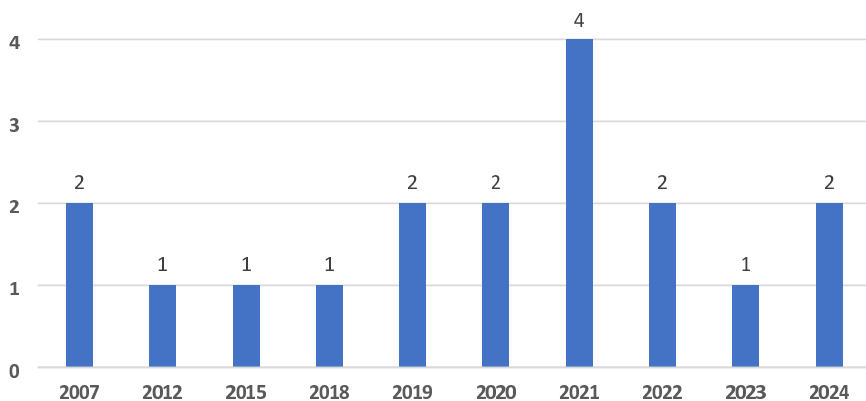
Findings

RQ1: what are the methodological characteristics of learner research on singular *they*?

Table 3 presents a summary of the methodological characteristics of the 18 studies included in this review. Most studies were published in recent years, as illustrated in Fig. 2.

Table 3 Summary of the methodological characteristics of the selected studies ($n=18$)

	<i>k</i>	%
L1 background		
<i>One</i>		
Chinese	7	38.9
Arabic	1	5.6
Filipino	1	5.6
German	1	5.6
Macedonian	1	5.6
Russian	1	5.6
Swedish	1	5.6
<i>Two</i>		
Finnish, Swedish	1	5.6
Polish, Iranian	1	5.6
<i>Three or more</i>		
	3	16.7
Educational level		
Tertiary	14	77.8
Secondary, tertiary	1	5.6
Others	3	16.7
Data source		
<i>Number of data source</i>		
One	9	50.0
Two	7	22.2
Three	2	11.1
<i>Type of data source</i>		
Elicitation test	13	72.2
Interview	5	27.8
Survey	4	22.2
Corpus	4	22.2
Self-paced reading	2	11.1

**Fig. 2** Number of studies published by year

As shown in Table 3, researchers examined diverse populations and utilized an array of data sources. Learners can be geographically grouped into two broad regions, including Asia (e.g., China, Iran, and the Philippines) and Europe (e.g., Germany, Sweden, Finland, Poland, and Macedonia). Their L1s represent a range of typological backgrounds, including Sino-Tibetan (Chinese), Afro-Asiatic (Arabic), Austronesian (Filipino), Indo-European (e.g., Swedish, German, and Persian), and Uralic (Finnish) languages. Despite this broad coverage of L1s, a sizable number of studies focused on L1 Chinese learners (38.9%), followed by those examining a group of learners with three or more L1s (16.7%) to enable cross-linguistic comparisons (e.g., Ebrahimi and Hosseini 2021; Stormbom 2022) or access representative samples (e.g., Hekanaho 2020; LaScotte 2021). In terms of educational levels, the majority of studies investigated university students (77.8%), with a limited focus on younger learners at the primary and secondary school levels.

The examination of data sources reveals several noteworthy insights. First, half of the studies drew on a single source, while the remaining studies administered multiple instruments, such as the combination of an elicitation test and an interview, to triangulate their findings. Second, elicitation tests emerged as the most popular data source (72.2%), followed by interviews (27.8%), corpora (22.2%), and surveys (22.2%). Elicitation tests were included in all studies that utilized multiple data sources, with the exception of Ma et al. (2022). Third, corpora served as the sole data source in all studies that involved corpus data (e.g., Stormbom 2018, 2019).

RQ2: To what extent do learners perform on singular *they* in genderunspecified contexts?"

Following the data sources utilized in studies, three themes emerged from the synthesis regarding singular *they*, including its use (elicitation test, corpus, interview, and survey), perception (survey and interview), and processing (self-paced reading). Taken together, these themes contribute to a comprehensive understanding of learners' performances on singular *they*. We provide a synthesis for each theme below.

Use of singular *they* as an epicene pronoun

A total of 17 studies examined the use of singular *they* as an epicene pronoun among learners. This strand encompasses five studies using elicitation tests as the sole data source, eight studies using elicitation tests as the primary or secondary source, and four studies analyzing corpus data. Overall, this body of research presents a mixed picture regarding the use of singular *they* in gender-unspecified contexts.

Six studies showed that learners preferred generic *he* to denote a person of unspecified gender (e.g., *a doctor*), disfavoring other alternatives like singular *they* (Abudalbh 2012; Lee 2007, 2015; Stormbom 2018; Sudo 2007; Zhang and Yang 2021). This tendency reflects teachers' role as "guardians of grammar" rather than "agents for social language reform" in the classroom (Pauwels and Winter 2006, p. 128). For instance, Lee (2015) investigated the use of epicene pronouns among L1 Chinese learners with various elicitation tests. In a story continuation task, none of the participants produced singular *they* as an anaphoric to gender-indeterminate singular nouns

(e.g., *a manager*). In another slot-filling test item, half of the participants referred back to the indefinite pronoun *someone* using generic *he*, and one-third of them preferred *he or she*, while very few favored singular *they*. Similar findings were reported among L1 Chinese and Arabic learners by Lee (2007) and Abudalbh (2012), who employed similar elicitation tests such as slot-filling, sentence completion, and multiple-choice tests. These results indicated a significant lack of awareness of singular *they* as a gender-neutral means among learners in traditionally male-dominated societies such as China and Arab countries.

Zhang and Yang (2021) conducted a corpus-based study examining L1 Chinese learners' use of epicene pronouns. They analyzed English essays from a nationwide corpus written by L1 Chinese learners from 2003 to 2007. Their findings revealed that generic *he* was the most frequently used epicene pronoun for indefinite and definite antecedents, and in contrast, singular *they* was the least used pronoun. This demonstrates a strong tendency among L1 Chinese learners to favor generic *he* during the data collection period. Stormbom (2018) conducted a similar corpus inquiry analyzing essays written before 2009 by learners representing thirteen L1 language backgrounds (mostly European languages) and concluded that generic *he* predominated over singular *they* and *he or she* for learners from most L1 backgrounds, such as Russian, French, and Dutch.

Shifting away from heavy reliance on generic *he*, three studies (Stormbom 2018; Zhang et al. 2020; Zhang and Yang 2024) indicated *he or she* as the most frequently chosen pronoun, surpassing both generic *he* and singular *they* by a significant margin. While Stormbom (2018) found that learners from such L1 backgrounds as Russian and French used generic *he* the most, those from L1 Spanish and Polish backgrounds opted for *he or she* the most. This trend is also confirmed by Zhang et al.'s (2020) and Zhang and Yang's (2024) investigations into Chinese EFL learners. The difference between the two studies lies in that Zhang and Yang (2024) reported the precedence of generic *he* over singular *they*, while these two pronouns were closer in usage in Zhang et al. (2020).

Conversely, the remaining nine studies reported positive findings in support of using singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts (Ebrahimi and Hosseini 2021; LaScotte 2021; Hekanaho 2020; Reilly-Thornton 2021; Speyer and SchleeF 2019; Stojanovska-Ilievska 2024; Stormbom 2019, 2022; Tarrayo 2024). For example, eliciting written responses from learners of eight L1 backgrounds (mostly European languages), Stormbom (2022) found that singular *they* was generally preferred for non-gender-biased antecedents such as *a person*, *the average user*, and *someone*.

Similarly, Tarrayo (2024) revealed that half of L1 Filipino learners endorsed the use of singular *they* to denote the gender-neutral antecedent *a student*, while very few of them continued to rely on generic *he*. In LaScotte's (2021) study, students across various proficiency levels and L1 backgrounds produced singular *they* to refer to *an ideal student* in descriptive essays. Among participants who used a single pronoun consistently throughout their writing (excluding those employing pronoun avoidance or mixing pronouns), about one-third of them wrote with singular *they*, closer to the proportion of students using generic *he* and *he or she*, representing an important step forward compared to studies showing the predominant use of generic *he* (Lee 2015; Zhang and Yang 2021).

Stormbom's (2019) corpus investigation also exhibited a growing trend of singular *they* replacing generic *he* as the default epicene pronoun. This study analyzed one existing academic corpus comprising term papers and Bachelor's theses composed by L1 Swedish learners in 2014 as part of the data. The results showed that singular *they* accounted for half of the pronoun use, followed by *he or she* and generic *he*. This suggests an increasing preference for singular *they* in Swedish university settings during the mid-2010s. Likewise, Stojanovska-Ilievska's (2024) corpus study highlights the wide use of singular *they* among L1 Macedonian learners.

Among the nine studies, four studies gathered additional survey and interview data to delve deeper into the reasons behind the preference for using singular *they* found in each study. In Ebrahimi and Hosseini's (2021) study, participants were also asked to explain the rationale for each pronoun choice and where they heard about singular *they*. Two pertinent findings were revealed. First, most participants cited *gender neutrality* as the reason for selecting singular *they*. Second, approximately half of the L1 Polish students and one-third of the L1 Iranian students reported having heard of singular *they*, with the two primary sources being school education and media exposure.

Speyer and Schleef (2019) also made a similar attempt to investigate how L1 German participants became aware of singular *they*. Their findings indicate that reading materials, the usage of this pronoun by others, and teacher instructions were the main sources of exposure. Different from Ebrahimi and Hosseini's (2021) written task format, Reilly-Thornton (2021) examined the spoken use of epicene pronouns among 11 L1 Chinese learners in response to 15 speaking prompts. Semi-structured interviews indicated that most participants perceived singular noun phrases (e.g., *a teacher*, NPs) as representing a group of people, leading them to conceptualize singular *they* as plural *they*. This finding is particularly interesting, given that the NPs used in these speaking prompts are syntactically and semantically singular. In addition, some participants noted that they had previously used gender-neutral language. Hekanaho (2020) revealed that the perceived exclusivity of gendered pronouns like generic *he* and the inclusivity of singular *they* drove the increased use of singular *they* by L1 Swedish and Finnish learners.

Perception of singular *they* as an epicene pronoun

Three studies probed into learners' attitudes towards and beliefs in the use of singular *they* as an epicene pronoun, revealing varied results. For example, Ma et al. (2022) employed a five-point Likert scale to assess among L1 Chinese learners their likelihood of using *he*, *she*, and *they* to refer to a non-gender-biased singular NP in various sentences. Their findings showed that L1 English L1 speakers generally accepted singular *they* for all antecedent types, including masculine-gendered nouns (e.g., *a truck driver*), feminine-biased nouns (e.g., *a nurse*), and neutral nouns (e.g., *a runner*). In stark contrast, L1 Chinese learners, regardless of their proficiency levels, regarded singular *they* as the least acceptable option for all antecedent types. In contrast, Hekanaho (2020) found that the majority of L1 Finnish and Swedish learners accepted the use of singular *they* in non-gendered contexts, aligning with the preference of L1 English speakers.

Tarrayo (2024) explored EFL instructors' views on using and teaching singular *they* in academic writing, with these instructors also being L1 Filipino learners themselves. The survey and interview data showed that most instructors endorsed the use of singular *they* in academic contexts and that most instructors expressed positive attitudes toward incorporating singular *they* into their academic writing instructions to encourage gender equality and inclusiveness. For example, they explicitly addressed singular *they* in their classrooms by fostering open discussions and granting students the freedom to use singular *they* in their writing. Nevertheless, some instructors opposed singular *they* as a suitable epicene pronoun by adhering to linguistic prescriptivism and traditional gender norms despite recognizing its gender-inclusive potential.

Processing of singular *they* as an epicene pronoun

Two studies addressed the processing of epicene pronouns by learners, with both studies revealing that learners did not have much difficulty in integrating singular *they* with a singular gender-neutral antecedent. Speyer and Schleef (2019) found that advanced L1 German learners' processing of *he*, *he or she*, and *they* was similar to that of L1 English speakers. In a similar fashion, Ma et al. (2022) showed that both learners and L1 English speakers were generally not disrupted by reading singular *they*. However, a spill-over effect was found among learners with lower proficiency, who spent a longer time reading the chunk appearing after singular *they*.

RQ3: Factors influencing learners' performances of singular *they*

While Lee (2015) and Stojanovska-Ilievska (2024) found no significant effects for variables like learner age or year of study at university, several influencing factors did emerge, explaining learners' pronominal choice of singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts. Table 4 outlines these factors, which we categorized into learner, linguistic, and contextual groups.

Learner-related factors

Gender Lee (2007) found significant gender differences, though not consistent across all items in the elicitation tests, in the use of epicene pronouns among L1 Chinese learners, such that more male participants chose singular *they* to refer to indefinite pronouns like *someone* and *no one*, while more women preferred *he or she* in items with noun phrases *a teacher*, *a shop assistant*, and *a secretary* as the gender-unspecified antecedents. However, Stojanovska-Ilievska (2024) investigated L1 Macedonian learners' use of the three epicene pronouns and revealed no gender differences between male and female students.

L1 background Three studies examined and confirmed the role of learners' L1 in influencing their epicene pronoun usage. In a corpus study, Stormbom (2018) analyzed epicene pronoun usage across learners from 13 L1 backgrounds. The study

Table 4 Factors influencing the performances of singular *they*

Category	Influencing factors	Study
Learner	Gender	Lee (2007)
	L1 background	Abudalbuh (2012), Stormbom (2018, 2022)
	English proficiency	Ma et al. (2022), Speyer and Schleeef (2019)
Linguistic	Exposure to singular <i>they</i>	Ebrahimi and Hosseini (2021), Speyer and Schleeef (2019)
	Antecedent type	Lee (2007, 2015), Stojanovska-Ilievska (2024), Stormbom (2018, 2019, 2022), Reilly-Thornton (2021), Zhang et al. (2020), Zhang and Yang (2021, 2024)
	Contextual	
	Gender stereotyping	Abudalbuh (2012), Lee (2007), Sudo (2007), Stormbom (2018, 2019), Zhang et al. (2020), Zhang and Yang (2024)
	School culture	Tarrayo (2024)
	Time	Stormbom (2019)

showed that learners whose L1s encoded the traditional masculine-generic *he*, such as Russian and Italian, tended to heavily deploy generic *he* and, thus accordingly, used singular *they* minimally. Stormbom (2022) confirmed this trend through elicitation tests with learners from eight different L1s in the sense that L1 Danish, Swedish, and Finnish learners were the most frequent users of singular *they*, whereas their L1 Italian and Russian counterparts used singular *they* the least. Focusing on L1 Arabic learners, whose L1 favors male-biased social norms, Abudalbuh (2012) found that in contrast to L1 English speakers, who frequently used singular *they*, L1 Arabic learners predominantly employed generic *he* and used singular *they* the least.

English language proficiency Speyer and Schleeef (2019) demonstrated that as learners progressed in their proficiency from Level B (independent user) to Level C (proficient user), according to the Common European Framework of Reference for Language (CEFR), their explicit knowledge of singular *they* also increased. By using self-paced reading tasks that examined the processing aspect, Ma et al. (2022) revealed that while learners were generally not disrupted in their reading of singular *they*, low-proficiency learners experienced a processing delay when reading the chunks that followed singular *they* (i.e., spill-over effect). Together, these two studies underscore the role of English language proficiency in the acquisition and processing of singular *they*.

Exposure to singular *they* Ebrahimi and Hosseini (2021) and Speyer and Schleeef (2019) found through surveys and interviews that external input sources, such as

school education, reading materials, and media coverage, play significant roles in shaping learners's knowledge of singular *they*.

Linguistic factor

Antecedent type Antecedent individuation has been identified as an important linguistic factor in ten studies (Lee 2007, 2015; Stojanovska-Ilievska 2024; Stormbom 2018, 2019, 2022; Reilly-Thornton 2021; Zhang et al. 2020, Zhang and Yang 2021, 2024), referring to the extent to which an antecedent is perceived as a specific individual (Newman 1998). Stormbom (2018) proposed the scale of antecedent individuation to account for how different types of antecedents affect the use of singular *they*. According to this scale, the degree of individuation decreases from definite NPs (e.g., *the student*) and indefinite NPs (e.g., *a student*) to quantificational NPs (e.g., *every person*) and indefinite pronouns (e.g., *someone*). As we move toward the less individuated end of this scale, singular *they* is more likely to be chosen over generic *he* as the anaphoric pronoun of choice. For instance, the use of singular *they* increases when referring to *a student* than to *the student*, as the former represents a less individuated antecedent.

In Stormbom's (2018) study, singular *they* exhibited more co-reference with quantificational NPs (17.1%) than with definite NPs (6.7%). Similarly, Stormbom's (2019) analyses demonstrated a significantly higher occurrence of singular *they* when referring anaphorically to indefinite pronouns (92.3%) compared to definite NPs (44.8%) and indefinite NPs (31.8%). Notably, some studies uncovered patterns that did not fully align with the scale of antecedent individuation. For example, Zhang and Yang (2021) reported more occurrences of singular *they* associated with definite NPs (12.6%) than with indefinite NPs (5.9%), contrary to what the scale would predict.

Contextual factors

Gender stereotyping Social gender or gender stereotyping has been identified as a context-dependent factor, influencing the pronominal choice of epicene pronouns (Abudalbuh 2012; Lee 2007; Stormbom 2018, 2019; Zhang et al. 2020; Zhang and Yang 2024). Abudalbuh (2012) found that Arabic-L2 learners tended to use generic *he* to reference a male-stereotyped noun such as *a mechanic*. In Lee's (2007) study of L1 Chinese learners, *a teacher* displayed a higher proportion of co-reference with singular *they* compared to *a chairman* because the latter is more likely to evoke a male-specific reference. In this sense, gender stereotyping is closely tied to the degree of individuation (Stormbom 2019); the main distinction lies in its strong reliance on social contexts because a male-dominant noun in one culture may be perceived as gender-neutral in another.

School culture Sudo (2007) revealed that singular *they* was rarely used among L1 Russian learners to refer to the non-gendered antecedents and noted that non-sexist

language reforms were not embraced in secondary schools, largely because mandatory standardized tests adopted by schools often failed to reflect an awareness of these changes. Similarly, Tarrayo (2024) also highlighted the impact of school culture on language use. Despite their awareness of using singular *they* as a gender-neutral means to prompt inclusion in academic settings, some teachers in the Philippines reported a lack of institutional support for its use. Their preferences for the gendered pronouns *he* and *he or she* were shaped not by their gender prejudice but by their attempt to prevent confusion among young learners.

Time As to temporal influences, Stormbom's (2019) diachronic study revealed a notable upward trend in the use of singular *they*, increasing from 0% in the 1970s to 24.2% in the 1990s and reaching 56.5% in the 2010s. This rise in singular *they* was accompanied by a significant decline in the use of generic *he*.

Discussion

This systematic review provides an updated snapshot of how learners of English use, perceive, and process singular *they* used to refer to a single individual whose gender is unknown or undisclosed in a given context. Singular *they* faces two main entrenched competitors, generic *he* and *he or she*, both of which have gradually fallen out of favor among L1 English speakers in recent decades (Balhorn 2004; Baranowski 2002; Ma et al. 2022; Paulwels 2001), due to their associations with gender inequality and exclusion in today's gender-diverse society. This review study draws on existing scholarship on singular *they* conducted among learners of English and revolves around three research questions: the notable methodological characteristics of this research line, the extent to which learners have responded to this trend of adopting singular *they* in gender-non-specified contexts, and factors influencing learners' performances of singular *they*.

Methodological characteristics

Our review showed that existing studies utilized a variety of data sources to examine learners from diverse L1 backgrounds, focusing on singular *they* in relation to its use, perception, and processing. Most studies employed elicitation methods – elicitation tests, surveys, and interviews – to investigate the use and perception of singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts. This aligns with the findings by Riazi et al. (2023), who surveyed 696 empirical articles published in *TESOL Quarterly* over the past five decades and found elicitation methods to be the most commonly used research approach.

Among the three types of data sources derived from elicitation methods, we found that elicitation tests were used most frequently, indicating a strong focus on the use of singular *they*. To help researchers delve deeper into why learners may refrain from using singular *they* and how they perceive it, more detail-oriented methods may be

necessary, such as think-aloud protocols, narrative inquiry, and grounded theory. For example, employing the grounded theory approach alongside narratives that explore learners' personal experiences with epicene pronouns could facilitate a rich exploration of the dynamics influencing the use and perception of singular *they* under specific cultural contexts (Lal et al. 2012).

On a more encouraging note, we found that half of the reviewed studies integrated two or three data sources, enabling the findings from each source to complement or supplement one another. This triangulation approach enhances the robustness of the research findings and provides a more comprehensive understanding of singular *they* within a single study.

Additionally, a significant portion of the studies concentrated on learners at the tertiary level. This observation resonates with Godfroid and Andringa's (2023) assertion in the field of second language acquisition that "researchers tend to focus on those who are most like themselves, university students" (p. 982). As a cautionary note, our understanding of singular *they* based on this review is largely limited to how *colleged* learners *use* this pronoun.

Learner performances with singular *they*

Since different data sources addressed different facets of learners' performances with singular *they*, we discussed each facet separately. Regarding the *use* of singular *they*, the present review reveals mixed findings. Earlier studies (Abudaljuh 2012; Lee 2007, 2015; Stormbom 2018; Sudo 2007) indicated that learners predominantly relied on generic *he* to denote an individual of unknown gender, with singular *they* being used infrequently in gender-neutral contexts.

In contrast, more recent empirical studies (e.g., Ebrahimi and Hosseini 2021; Reilly-Thornton 2021; Stormbom 2019, 2022) generally revealed that learners demonstrated a strong preference for singular *they* in genderless contexts, making it the most commonly used epicene pronoun, except for three studies (Zhang et al. 2020; Zhang and Yang 2021, 2024) pointing to great struggles with using singular *they* by L1 Chinese learners. Zhang and Yang (2021) reported a dominance of generic *he*, which may be understandable given that their corpus data were collected between 2003 and 2007, reflecting learners' earlier epicene pronoun usage. Through the administration of elicitation tests, Zhang et al. (2020) and Zhang and Yang (2024) found the use of *he or she* surpassed that of generic *he*. The results may suggest that the epicene pronoun use by L1 Chinese learners is in flux.

Overall, this shift in epicene pronoun usage can be interpreted as reflective of evolving social movements, as social ideologies and pronoun use are closely intertwined (Stormbom 2022). The use of generic *he* is problematic because it is inherently male-biased and fails to serve as a truly generic option (Barron 2020). In response to the demand for greater visibility for female presence during the second feminist movement, *he or she* gained popularity (Stormbom 2024). However, its binary framing excludes non-binary individuals not identifying as males or females. Singular *they* has consequently prevailed as the most inclusive alternative (LaScotte 2016).

These historical changes in epicene pronoun use are well manifested in Stormbom's (2019) corpus study, which analyzed L1 Swedish learners' use of English epi-

cene pronouns in academic texts from the 1970s through the 2010s. The diachronic analysis displayed a steep decline in the use of generic *he*, then a fluctuating yet overall increasing trend for *he or she*, and finally a significant rise in the adoption of singular *they*. These changes can be taken as compelling evidence that L1 Swedish learners aligned themselves with the evolution of epicene pronouns. We reckon that one reason for this alignment may be linked to Sweden's social climate. Often celebrated as "one of the world's most gender-equal countries" (Milles 2011, p. 21), Sweden has actively pursued feminist language reforms to the point where they even introduced the new gender-neutral pronoun *hen* into the Swedish pronominal system in 2012 (Gustafsson Sendén et al. 2015).

It is interesting to note that the publication year 2020 appears to be a significant turning point in singular *they* usage. Studies published prior to this point in time generally exhibited a less preference for singular *they* while those published afterward forecasted an overall positive prospect for its use as the desirable epicene pronoun. This period also witnessed the release of updated academic writing style manuals, the 7th edition of the APA manual and the 9th edition of the *MLA Handbook*, both of which endorse the use of singular *they* in academic contexts. While it is difficult to determine whether these style manuals have influenced to varying degrees the recent increase in singular *they* usage observed in some studies (e.g., Reilly-Thornton 2021; Tarrayo 2024; Stormbom 2022), or the other way around, the APA's and MLA's adoptions of singular *they* are likely to impact its use in academic settings in the future. It is also evident that the number of studies investigating singular *they* will likely continue to grow, making it an emerging topic of inquiry, especially as most research has been published relatively recently after 2020.

Notably, the use of singular *they* is a time-sensitive matter that warrants our attention. Gustafsson Sendén et al. (2015) documented a case in Swedish where the newly coined third gender-neutral pronoun *hen*, similar to the singular *they* in English, was introduced to the existing Swedish pronominal system. Initially, the majority of the Swedish population frowned upon this addition, but within two years, they embraced this term with positive attitudes. Their study suggested that time was one of the strongest factors influencing this shift in perception. Building on this, we anticipate that singular *they* will also be readily accepted as the default epicene pronoun among learners of English. Unlike the coined pronoun *hen* in Swedish, the familiarization of singular *they* may differ for learners of English, as most learners do not need to acquire a new word but rather reconceptualize or "restructure the existing knowledge of the plural feature of *they*" (Ma et al. 2022, p. 4).

In terms of how learners perceived singular *they*, mixed attitudes and a misalignment between perception and practice emerged. On one hand, some learners embraced singular *they* to cultivate gender inclusivity and equality, while others deemed this usage highly inappropriate. On the other hand, some instructors, as reported by Tarrayo (2024), opposed the incorporation of singular *they* into their teaching despite acknowledging its benefits; they tend to "sacrifice the notion of gender inclusivity and equality for linguistic prescriptivism" (Tarrayo 2024, p. 635). The divergence in attitudes underscores the complexities and challenges of integrating singular *they* into language education, raising concerns about the effectiveness of classroom instructions as a means to craft a more accepting and inclusive linguistic environ-

ment. Instructors' adherence to gendered linguistic practices such as generic *he* and *he or she*, along with their resistance to singular *they*, may not only hinder learners' understanding of inclusive language but also reinforce gendered social norms. Nevertheless, given education's deep commitment to diversity, equality, and inclusion, language education must evolve to align with three principles.

The processing of singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts presents a positive picture, such that learners were not generally hindered by the existence of singular *they*, even if they did not fully recognize it as a legitimate pronoun. Ma et al. (2022) interpreted this result as task-specific. In online reading tasks, where time and cognitive resources are limited, learners tend to prioritize the overall meaning of the sentence over its grammaticality.

Factors influencing learner performances on singular *they*

The influencing factors are identified as an explanatory scheme. From the analyses of each study emerged eight factors, organized into three categories. Some factors, such as gender and L1s, were inconsistent across studies, indicating the intricacies of using epicene pronouns, singular *they* in particular.

The first category encompasses four learner-related factors, among which learner gender is the only demographic variable identified in these studies and other factors are related to learners' language. Lee (2007) found that women exhibited a greater preference for *he or she* when referring to a *secretary*, a noun culturally associated with females, compared to their male counterparts. Their preference may indicate the intersection of gender and gender stereotyping as female learners seek their representation in pronoun usage (*he or she*).

The second factor is L1 background. Since individuals bring unique patterns of prior experience, including their L1s, to the learning or use of an additional language (McManus 2021), it is reasonable to expect that learners' L1 linguistic structures and social norms influence their use of singular *they*. Stormbom (2018, 2022) corroborated the presence of such cross-linguistic influences. However, in Ebrahimi and Hosseini's (2021) cross-cultural study, L1 was not found to have a significant cross-linguistic effect, as both L1 Iranian and Polish learners exhibited comparable usage of singular *they*. This might be attributable to a heightened awareness of singular *they* in gender-neutral contexts among both groups, as many learners had been exposed to this usage.

In addition, in line with usage-based theories (Tyler 2010), exposure to singular *they* and overall English proficiency also serve as two functioning factors, and a couple of studies noted that learners had heard of the gender-inclusive language in general and singular *they* in particular (Ebrahimi and Hosseini 2021; Reilly-Thornton 2021; Speyer and Schlee 2019; Sudo 2007).

The second category pertains to the linguistic factor with the type of antecedents being the sole variable. It is assumed that antecedents with a higher degree of individuation – ranked in descending order as definite NPs, indefinite NPs, quantificational NPs, and indefinite pronouns – are less likely to be associated with singular *they*. This assumption is supported by Lee (2007) and Stormbom (2018) while Zhang and

Yang's (2021) study contradicts it. This implies that additional factors may be at play influencing the relationship between the antecedent type and the use of singular *they*.

The three factors in the third category relate to gender stereotyping, school culture, and time. Gender stereotyping or social gender may interact with antecedent individuation. Sudo (2007) and Tarrayo (2024) reported that institutional barriers might prevent learners from gaining quality exposure to singular *they*; in the school contexts, it is often construed as a grammatically incorrect usage and damages linguistic purism in terms of linguistic prescription.

These influencing factors strengthen the notion of singular *they* as a multi-faceted linguistic phenomenon, encompassing grammatical, pragmatic, psycholinguistic (cross-linguistic influence), sociolinguistic (social norms), and sociocultural considerations. Further implicating this matter is the understanding that language use and social practices are inextricably intertwined (Stormbom 2022). This interlocking relationship captures the essence and practicality of an individual's funds of knowledge, shaped by both language and language use. As language fundamentally shapes our cognitive mapping, perception, and developmental pathway (Pae 2020), promoting the use of singular *they* is theoretically, conceptually, and practically essential for fostering inclusion and equality as a socioculturally constructed linguistic activity.

Limitations

We acknowledge several limitations that may affect the interpretability of learners' use of epicene pronouns. Although this review suggests a shift from generic *he* to singular *they*, the uneven distribution of learners' L1 backgrounds across the reviewed studies may restrict the generalizability of this finding to learners from more homogeneous linguistic backgrounds.

Despite the increasing use of singular *they* reported in recently published studies, this review has two additional limitations that should be noted. First, nearly all of the reviewed studies focus on tertiary-level participants, resulting in the underrepresentation of learners in primary, secondary, and non-formal educational contexts. Consequently, the findings may not fully capture how singular *they* has been used, interpreted, or negotiated across different stages of language development and instructional settings.

Second, the predominance of elicitation-based instruments, such as sentence completion tasks and multiple-choice tests, may not fully capture learners' spontaneous use of singular *they* in naturalistic communication. This reliance also constrains our understanding of how contextual, interactional, and discourse-level factors shape pronoun choice in real-world language use. Accordingly, the findings of this review should be interpreted cautiously in light of these limitations.

Recommendations for teaching and research

In closing, given the two noteworthy findings that (1) learners from certain L1 backgrounds, especially L1 Chinese learners, have lagged in the adoption of singular *they* as the preferred epicene pronoun, and (2) most studies leaned towards college-

aged learners as the participants and elicitation instruments as data sources, we conclude this review by proffering implications for both pedagogical practice and future research.

Implications for EFL teaching

The present review highlights several pedagogical implications for teaching singular *they* in various learning contexts. First and foremost, explicit instruction on singular *they*, including explanations of its grammatical functions and its role in promoting inclusive communication, should be enacted at multiple levels, given the importance of exposure to singular *they* in facilitating its use (Ebrahimi and Hosseini 2021; Speyer and Schleef 2019).

For instance, teachers can provide learners with ample authentic input featuring singular *they* and explain the rationale behind appropriate pronoun usage, including the influence of feminist social movements. Students can also be invited to complete a project to explore common gendered language practices in daily life, such as generic *he*, and to reflect deeply on the consequences these practices may incur. These practices are particularly important for young learners as they develop their initial cognitive mapping and awareness of gender. Moreover, due to the influence of L1 backgrounds on epicene pronoun usage (Abudalbh 2012), teachers need to provide culturally sensitive explanations that acknowledge learners' L1 norms and beliefs about gender, while illustrating how English increasingly employs singular *they* in both formal and informal contexts.

Second, curriculum designers and materials developers can support this goal by incorporating authentic input, such as reading texts, dialogues, and multimedia content, that models gender-neutral language use. Classroom activities can further scaffold learners' engagement with singular *they* through project-based tasks, including collaborative writing, peer feedback, and discussion exercises, which allow learners to apply inclusive language in meaningful contexts. Third, institutional and curricular support is essential to reinforce these practices, providing professional development, appropriate teaching materials, and assessment frameworks that recognize gender-inclusive usage.

Together, these strategies not only enhance learners' grammatical competence but also cultivate intercultural awareness, preparing EFL students to navigate and contribute to global English communication in ways that are both pragmatically appropriate and socially responsible.

Recommendations for future research

This review opens new avenues for further research. First, researchers may consider replication studies by diversifying learner samples based on their L1 backgrounds and learning contexts. Language differs significantly in many respects, providing exciting opportunities to venture into how the gendered language use in one language impacts the use of another. For example, while some languages like English do not assign gender to inanimate objects such as tables and books, others have complex gender systems where objects carry gender labels. In languages like French and Spanish,

objects are typically assigned either *masculine* or *feminine* gender; in contrast, languages such as German and Russian include *neuter* as a third gender (Sudo 2007). These differences make singular *they* a fertile ground for examining conceptual transfer in the context of learning English as an additional language.

Second, in light of the current overemphasis on university students, future research could investigate younger learners, including primary and secondary school students, to explore their early perception, beliefs, and awareness regarding the use of singular *they*. In addition, studies could explore learners in non-formal educational contexts, such as language clubs, online learning platforms, or community programs, to capture a broader range of learning experiences. Addressing these underexplored populations and contexts would not only deepen our understanding of how singular *they* is acquired and integrated across different learning environments but also inform pedagogical practices and policies that support inclusive language use from early stages of education onward. In addition, longitudinal designs could also be employed to trace how learners adopt and use singular *they* over time, providing insights into developmental trajectories.

Third, given the underuse of singular *they* among college-aged learners, implementing targeted interventions would be beneficial for expanding their understanding of this usage and fostering their intercultural communication competence toward gender-neutral practices. From the research perspective, it would be meaningful to assess whether explicit instructions, such as project-based language teaching technique (Beckett and Slater 2005), could significantly impact their linguistic knowledge of singular *they*, content knowledge of social movements that drive this pronoun usage, and most importantly, skill in using gender-neutral language; this is an essential competence that enables effective intercultural communication in the face of the contemporary gender-diverse world.

Fourth, updated large-scale corpora are essential to explore whether learners align with current trends in using singular *they* as a gender-neutral form. Previous studies all relied on established corpora. Data deriving from these corpora may not accurately reflect learners' *current* pronoun usage and thus prevent us from gaining a renewed understanding of learners' most recent practices in relation to epicene pronouns, although historical data do provide valuable insights into its evolution (see Stormbom 2019).

Next, theoretical frameworks from neighboring disciplines – such as psychology, education, communication, and sociology – could provide fresh perspectives on the study of singular *they*. For instance, the ecological perspective invites an in-depth exploration of how the use of singular *they* may be constrained by situational factors at the micro, meso, exo, and macro levels, and how these factors interact with one another. Understanding these constraints and their interrelations offers valuable insights for informing policies aimed at addressing existing gendered language practices. In turn, awareness of these barriers can help language users and educators develop more effective strategies to promote inclusive and socially responsible language use, facilitating meaningful change both within educational settings and in broader societal communication.

Acknowledgements We would like to express our gratitude to Dr. Evthokia Saclarides at the University of Cincinnati for her invaluable guidance during the preparation of this review and for her insightful feedback, which significantly enhanced an earlier version of the manuscript.

Author contributions Hanzhong Sun – Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – original draft, and Writing – reviewing and editing; Xiao (Peter) LUO – Methodology and Writing – reviewing and editing; Hye K. Pae - Writing – reviewing and editing.

Funding This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

Data availability No new data were generated in this study. All sources reviewed are publicly available and cited in the reference section.

Declarations

Ethical approval This article does not involve human participants; therefore, ethical approval was not required.

Informed consent This article does not involve human participants; therefore, informed consent was not required.

Conflict of interest The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Open Access This article is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License, which permits use, sharing, adaptation, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons licence, and indicate if changes were made. The images or other third party material in this article are included in the article's Creative Commons licence, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the article's Creative Commons licence and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder. To view a copy of this licence, visit <http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>.

References

- *Abudalbh M (2012) Ideology, gender roles, and pronominal choice: a sociolinguistic analysis of the use of English third person generic pronouns by native speakers of Arabic [Unpublished doctoral dissertation]. University of Kansas
- American Psychological Association (2020) Publication manual of the American Psychological Association, 7th edn. APA
- Avery N, Marsden E (2019) A meta-analysis of sensitivity to grammatical information during self-paced reading: towards a framework of reference for reading time effect sizes. *Stud Second Lang Acquis* 41(5):1055–1087. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0272263119000196>
- Bailey AH, LaFrance M, Dovidio JF (2019) Is man the measure of all things? A social cognitive account of androcentrism. *Pers Soc Psychol Rev* 23(4):307–331. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1088868318782848>
- Balhorn M (2004) The rise of epicene they. *J Engl Linguist* 32(2):79–104. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0075424204265824>
- Baranowski M (2002) Current usage of the epicene pronoun in written english. *J Socioling* 6(3):378–397. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9481.00193>
- Baron D (2020) What's your pronoun? Beyond he and she. Liveright Publishing, New York

- Batista da Costa M, Tenenbaum HR, Grandison A (2024) What do they mean? A systematic review on the interpretation, usage and acceptability of they. *Front Psychol* 15:1253356. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1253356>
- Beckett GH, Slater T (2005) The project framework: A tool for language, content, and skills integration. *ELT J* 59(2):108–116. <https://doi.org/10.1093/eltj/ccj024>
- Bradley ED (2020) The influence of linguistic and social attitudes on grammaticality judgments of singular ‘they’. *Lang Sci* 78:1–11. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.langsci.2020.101272>
- Bradley ED, Schmid M, Lombardo H (2019) Personality, prescriptivism, and pronouns: factors influencing grammaticality judgments of gender-neutral Language. *Engl Today* 35(4):41–52. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0266078419000397>
- * denotes the articles included in this review
- *Ebrahimi H, Hosseini HM (2021) Investigating the use of singular ‘they’ across two social contexts: A comparative study of Iranian and Polish EFL students. *Lang Teach Res Q* 24:65–85. <https://doi.org/10.32038/ltrq.2021.24.04>
- Elabor-Idemudia P (2012) Gender and identity in a globalized world. In: Dzisah J, Etkowitz H (eds) *The age of knowledge: the dynamics of universities, knowledge and society*. Brill, Leiden, pp 342–349
- Foertsch J, Gernsbacher MA (1997) In search of gender neutrality: is singular they a cognitively efficient substitute for generic he? *Psychol Sci* 8(2):106–111. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.1997.tb00691.x>
- Galvan JL, Galvan MC (2017) *Writing literature reviews: A guide for students of the social and behavioral sciences*. Taylor & Francis, New York
- Godfroid A, Andringa S (2023) Uncovering sampling biases, advancing inclusivity, and rethinking theoretical accounts in second Language acquisition: introduction to the special issue SLA for all? *Lang Learn* 74(4):981–1002. <https://doi.org/10.1111/lang.12620>
- Gong Z, Liu Y, Liu Y (2024) A comparative study of research questions written by L1 english authors and Chinese EFL scholars. *J Engl Acad Purp* 69:1–13. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2024.101383>
- Gustafsson Sendén M, Bäck EA, Lindqvist A (2015) Introducing a gender-neutral pronoun in a natural gender language: the influence of time on attitudes and behavior. *Front Psychol* 6:893. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2015.00893>
- *Hekanaho L (2020) *Gender and non-binary pronouns: usage, acceptability and attitudes* [Unpublished doctoral dissertation]. University of Helsinki
- Hinkel E (2018) Descriptive versus prescriptive grammar. *Tesol Encycl Engl Lang Teach* 1:1–6. <https://doi.org/10.1002/9781118784235.eelt0053>
- Hyland K (2016) Methods and methodologies in second Language writing research. *System* 59:116–125. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2016.05.002>
- Lal S, Suto M, Ungar M (2012) Examining the potential of combining the methods of grounded theory and narrative inquiry: A comparative analysis. *Qual Rep* 17(21):1–22. <https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2012.1767>
- LaScotte DK (2016) Singular they: an empirical study of generic pronoun use. *Am Speech* 91(1):62–80. <https://doi.org/10.1215/00031283-3509469>
- *LaScotte DK (2021) Nonnative english learners’ use and Understanding of singular they. *Lang Aware* 30(1):84–94. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09658416.2020.1869753>
- *Lee JF (2007) Acceptability of sexist Language among young people in Hong Kong. *Sex Roles* 56:285–295. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11199-006-9170-4>
- *Lee JF (2015) Chairperson or chairman? A study of Chinese EFL teachers’ gender inclusivity. *Aust Rev Appl Linguist* 38(1):22–47. <https://doi.org/10.1075/aral.38.1.02lee>
- *Ma Z, Wu S, Xu S (2022) Acceptance and online interpretation of gender-neutral pronouns: performance asymmetry by Chinese english as a foreign Language learners. *Front Psychol* 12:765777. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.765777>
- McManus K (2021) *Crosslinguistic influence and second Language learning*. Routledge, New York
- Miller MM, James LE (2009) Is the generic pronoun he still comprehended as excluding women? *Am J Psychol* 122(4):483–496. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/20066927/>
- Milles K (2011) Feminist Language planning in Sweden. *Curr Iss Lang Plan* 12(1):21–33. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14664208.2011.541388>
- Modern Language Association (2021) *MLA handbook*, 9th edn. MLA
- Mucchi-Faina A (2005) Visible or influential? Language reforms and gender (in) equality. *Soc Sci Inf* 44(1):189–215. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0539018405050466>

- Newman M (1998) What can pronouns tell us? A case study of english epicenes. *Stud Lang* 22(2):353–389. <https://doi.org/10.1075/sl.22.2.04new>
- Noll J, Lowry M, Bryant J (2018) Changes over time in the comprehension of he and they as epicene pronouns. *J Psycholinguist Res* 47:1057–1068. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10936-018-9577-4>
- Noviana AP, Indah RN (2023) Beyond binary: a gender and linguistic analysis of the reconstruction of pronoun ‘they’. *Annu Int Conf Lang Lit Media* 5:79–91. <https://doi.org/10.18860/aicollim.v5i1.2428>
- Nunez-Roman F, Gómez-Camacho A, Hunt-Gómez CI (2023) Gender-Inclusive textisms: how Spanish-speaking educational communities promote linguistic innovations on Twitter. *Linguist Educ* 76:1–8. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.linged.2023.101191>
- Ortega L (2015) Research synthesis. In: Paltridge B, Phakiti A (eds) *Research methods in applied linguistics: A practical resource*. Bloomsbury, London, pp 225–244
- Pae HK (2020) *Script effects as the hidden drive of the mind, cognition, and culture*. Springer Nature, London
- Paterson L (2014) British pronoun use, prescription, and processing: linguistic and social influences affecting ‘they’ and ‘he’. Palgrave Macmillan, New York
- Paterson L (2020) Non-sexist Language policy and the rise (and fall?) of combined pronouns in British and American written english. *J Engl Linguist* 48(3):258–281. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0075424220938949>
- Pauwels A (2001) Non-sexist Language reform and generic pronouns in Australian english. *Engl World-Wide* 22(1):105–119. <https://doi.org/10.1075/eww.22.1.06pau>
- Pauwels A, Winter J (2006) Gender inclusivity or ‘grammar rules OK’? Linguistic prescriptivism vs linguistic discrimination in the classroom. *Lang Educ* 20(2):128–140. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09500780608668717>
- *Reilly-Thornton A (2021) Gendered pronouns in Chinese EL2 speech: the case of epicene pronouns. *TEANGA: J Ir Association Appl Linguistics* 28:247–277. <https://doi.org/10.35903/teanga.v28i.697>
- Riazi AM, Ghanbar H, Marefat F, Fazel I (2023) Review and analysis of empirical articles published in TESOL quarterly over its lifespan. *Stud Second Lang Learn Teach* 13(4):811–841. <https://doi.org/10.14746/ssl.t.40217>
- Romiti A, Smith J (2022) An intercultural experience with a gender perspective between post-secondary students from Argentina and Canada. In: Banegas DL, Govender N (eds) *Gender diversity and sexuality in english Language education: new transnational voices*. Bloomsbury, New York, pp 29–44
- Samuel S, Cole G, Eacott MJ (2019) Grammatical gender and linguistic relativity: A systematic review. *Psychon Bull Rev* 26(6):1767–1786. <https://doi.org/10.3758/s13423-019-01652-3>
- Selvi AF, Galloway N, Rose H (2024) *Teaching english as an international Language*. Cambridge University Press, Cambridge
- *Speyer LG, Schleef E (2019) Processing ‘gender-neutral’ pronouns: A self-paced reading study of learners of english. *Appl Linguisit* 40(5):793–815. <https://doi.org/10.1093/applin/amy022>
- *Stojanovska-Ilievska N (2024) A corpus-based study of epicene pronouns used by Macedonian learners of english. *Open Linguist* 10(1):1–16. <https://doi.org/10.1515/opli-2024-0017>
- *Stormbom C (2018) Epicene pronouns in intermediate to advanced EFL writing. *Int J Learn Corpus Res* 4(1):1–22. <https://doi.org/10.1075/ijlcr.16016.sto>
- *Stormbom C (2019) Language change in L2 academic writing: the case of epicene pronouns. *J Engl Acad Purp* 38:95–105. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2019.02.001>
- Stormbom C (2020) Gendering in open access research articles: the role of epicene pronouns. *Engl Specif Purp* 60:193–204. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.esp.2020.08.001>
- *Stormbom C (2022) Singular they in english as a foreign Language. *Appl Linguisit Rev* 13(5):873–897. <https://doi.org/10.1515/applirev-2019-0115>
- Stormbom C (2024) Epicene pronouns new and old. In: Paterson LL (ed) *The Routledge handbook of pronouns*. Routledge, New York, pp 411–420
- Stout JG, Dasgupta N (2011) When he doesn’t mean you: Gender-exclusive Language as ostracism. *Pers Soc Psychol Bull* 37(6):757–769. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167211406434>
- *Sudo J (2007) Teaching new tendencies in gender usage in modern english. *ELT J* 61(1):12–19. <https://doi.org/10.1093/elt/ccl040>
- Tarrayo VN (2023) Blending words and worlds: Promises, practices, and predicaments of integrating gender perspectives into english Language teaching in the Philippines. *Asian J Engl Lang Stud* 11:151–165. <https://doi.org/10.59960/11.a8>
- *Tarrayo VN (2024) Using the third-person singular pronoun they in academic writing: perspectives from english Language teachers in Philippine universities. *Lang Aware* 33(3):625–648. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09658416.2023.2256652>

- Taylor S (2021) The use of singular they in professional writing. *Schwa: Lang Linguistics* 25(1):23–40
- Thompson B (2002) Multiracial feminism: recasting the chronology of second wave feminism. *Fem Stud* 28(2):337–360. <https://doi.org/10.2307/3178747>
- Tyler A (2010) Usage-based approaches to Language and their applications to second Language learning. *Annu Rev Appl Linguist* 30:270–291. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0267190510000140>
- Velázquez-Lora LA (2022) Including them and all the rest: Gender-neutral pronouns in EFL class. *J Lang Sex* 11(2):240–250. <https://doi.org/10.1075/jls.20025.vel>
- Willis M, Jozkowski KN (2018) Ladies first? Not so fast: linguistic sexism in peer-reviewed research. *J Sex Res* 55(2):137–145. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00224499.2017.1346058>
- Wyrick AJ (2021) Contemporary issues in terminology: using gender-inclusive language to create affirming spaces. In: Kite ME, Case KA, Williams WR (eds) *Navigating difficult moments in teaching diversity and social justice*. American Psychological Association, pp 179–194
- *Zhang X, Hong KH, Hwang KH (2020) Chinese university EFL learners' perceptions of the gender-neutral singular they in english. *Engl Lang Teach* 32(4):127–146. <https://doi.org/10.17936/pkelt.2020.32.4.7>
- *Zhang X, Yang H (2021) Gender voices in Chinese university students' english writing: A corpus study. *Linguis Educ* 64:1–10. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.linged.2021.100935>
- *Zhang X, Yang H (2024) Perception and usage of english epicene pronouns among L2 teachers in China-focusing on he, he or she and they. *Eur J Educ* 59(3):e12651. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ejed.12651>

Authors and Affiliations

Hanzhong Sun¹  · Xiao Peter LUO²  · Hye K. Pae¹ 

✉ Hanzhong Sun
sunhz@mail.uc.edu

¹ School of Education, University of Cincinnati, Cincinnati, OH, USA

² Centre for Foreign Languages, Beijing Normal-Hong Kong Baptist University, Zhuhai, Guangdong, China